

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2001-01-16

To the bahá'ís of the world

1 dearly loved friends,

As we write you this message, the conference of the continental coun-

2 selors approaches a triumphant conclusion.

3 for eight days the counselors from all the continents have consulted on

4 the next phase of the process of entry by troops. while they were meeting

5 during the first five days, 849 members of their Auxiliary boards from 172

6 countries were arriving at the bahá'í world center and paying their re-

7 spects at the holy Shrines in anticipation of the moment when they would

8 all come together in a series of soul-stirring events: ascent of the newly

built Terraces on mount carmel; circumambulation of the Shrine of the

9 báb; procession along the Arc path for a visit to the international Teaching

center building; a devotional ceremony to mark the occupation by the

10 Teaching center of its permanent seat; and subsequent joint consultations

11 concerning their indispensable role in the five year plan on which the bahá'í

12 world will embark at riḡván 2001.

The deliberations of the counselors themselves have been the heart of

13 these stupendous activities. Their consultations have been marked by a combination
of sobriety and effervescence that has refined the character of their discussions and illumined
understanding. it is clear from the confident

14 atmosphere in which they have conferred that their institution has reached a new
stage in its maturation. even though they function principally as

15 individuals, the counselors across all boards have become of one mind. by

16 internalizing and integrating the lessons and experiences of systematization called for
in the four year plan, they have indeed been transformed into

17 channels of unified thought. we appreciate that the new height in the evolu-

18 tion of their institution is a reflection, too, of the measure to which, with

19 their wise and constant advice, the Spiritual Assemblies and other institu-
 20 tions of the world community have evolved.

21 As the time for the conference drew near, there were signs that the faith
 22 had arrived at a point in its development beyond which a new horizon opens
 23 before us. Such intimations were communicated in our report last riḡván
 24 of the change in culture of the bahá'í community as training institutes 351.1

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352 2000–2001 • T h e T W e l v e m o n Th Pl a n

353 77emerged, as the construction projects on mount carmel approached their
 354 completion, and as the internal processes of institutional consolidation and
 355 the external processes towards world unity became more fully synchronized.

356 They were elaborated in the message we addressed to the conference of the
 357 continental boards of counselors a few days ago. but the extraordinary
 358 dynamics at work throughout the conference crystallized these indications
 359 into a recognizable reality. with a spirit of exultation we are moved to an-
 360 nounce to you: the faith of bahá'u'lláh now enters the fifth epoch of its
 361 formative Age.

362 recognition of this milestone falls within the patterns established by
 363 Shoghi effendi for marking measures of time in the history of the cause; he
 364 foresaw among these a succession of epochs occurring in the formative Age.

365 it must fill every devoted follower of bahá'u'lláh with joy and wonder that
 366 his Administrative order has reached so important a point at so crucial a
 367 time, when so many members of the institution of the counselors are gath-
 368 ered in splendid array at the world center of his faith. They will return to
 369 the far corners of the earth as torches aflame with the spirit of service. That
 370 they will pour fresh energy into their activities, there can be no doubt. Their
 371 efforts will surely widen the path leading to the success of the T twelve month
 372 plan, and through that to the launching at riḡván of the five year enterprise
 373 that will be the first in a series of plans to be pursued until the centenary of

374 the formative Age.

375 The counselors will leave here anticipating their early consultations with

376 National Spiritual Assemblies regarding the operation in their countries of

377 the forthcoming plan. with the involvement of their eager auxiliaries, they

378 will assist, too, in quickly moving the requisite planning process to regional

379 and local areas of the community in every land.

380 in the waning moments of these eventful days, our hearts are turned in

381 humble gratitude to the Ancient beauty for the abundance of the blessings

382 he has bestowed. The very earth of carmel is astir with the wonders of

383 his grace as she responds to the redemptive call he raised in the Tablet

384 bearing her name. his fervent wish expressed therein resounds in the souls

385 of his lovers throughout the planet: “o h, how i long to announce unto

386 every spot on the surface of the earth, and to carry to each one of its cit-ies, the

glad-tidings of this revelation. . . .”

387 351-1 The friends now gathered

388 351-1. gwb, no. 11.4.351.5

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352 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

353 77amid the splendor at carmel’s heart have heard it with new ears and have

354 reaffirmed their pledge to respond to this divine longing. may their exploits

355 in the Name of bahá scatter more widely the fragrance of his revelation,

356 strengthen more firmly the foundation of his institutions, and embolden

357 more resolutely the activities of his worldwide community, impelling for-

358 ward the process by which troop after troop will enter into the stronghold

359 of the Ark of Salvation.

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Laws of the Kitáb-i-Aqdas Not Yet Universally Applied

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]